While few doubt the influence of the RSS on the BJP and the multiplier effect its cadres bring to the party, it is necessary to more precisely quantify their relationship. To map this with exactitude, I carried out a special sorting exercise of the backgrounds of three categories of national BJP leaders: the first Modi cabinet of ministers in Delhi (2014–2019), the second Modi cabinet (2019) and the BJP's top office-bearers.

The journalist Rajiv Pundir and I studied publicly available information about each Union cabinet minister in both Modi regimes and the central office-bearers of the BJP at the national level to ascertain how many of these leaders had an RSS background. We aimed to identify the penetration of the RSS into the BJP, at least to the extent that could be numerically measured. To round off this analysis, we also studied one BJP state government, the cabinet of BJP's Shivraj Singh Chauhan in Madhya Pradesh, to understand just how many of its ministers had been with the RSS. It is important to clarify here that having an RSS background does not mean that a BJP functionary is currently a member of the Sangh. In fact, under RSS rules, any pracharak working for the BJP would have to resign his role in the Sangh.

The purpose of our exercise was to quantify the influence of RSS ideas on the BJP's top leadership. We found that exactly half of Modi's first cabinet—every second minister, that is—in 2014 (seventeen of thirty-four ministers) had an RSS or RSS-affiliate background (see Figure 12.5).

The second Modi cabinet appointed in 2019 also had a similar (but slightly lower) representation of leaders with an RSS background: 48 per cent (twelve of twenty-five cabinet ministers). A major cabinet addition in 2019 was that of ex-foreign secretary, S. Jaishankar, who had no political background, as external affairs minister. The larger council of ministers also had ministers of state with independent charge, like R.K. Singh (Power) and Hardeep Singh Puri (Urban Development), who had bureaucratic experience and no RSS background. A senior BJP leader, when questioned by the news portal *The Print* on the party's links with the RSS, made it clear that 'having an affiliation with the RSS is not a criterion to become a minister … to say someone is being promoted merely